

Yi Zhang

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Google Scholar

<https://yizhang96.github.io/>

EDUCATION

University of Southern California

Ph.D. in Psychology

Advisor: Leor Hackel, Ph.D.

Thesis: An emotion regulation framework for interpersonal moral disagreements

Expected May 2026

Los Angeles, CA

University of Southern California

M.A. in Psychology

2020 - 2022

Los Angeles, CA

New York University

B.A. Psychology, Philosophy (double major), *magna cum laude*

2014 - 2018

New York, NY

RESEARCH TOPICS

Social learning, moral cognition, empathy, emotion regulation, social networks

RESEARCH METHODS

Behavioral	Online studies (CloudResearch, Prolific, Pavlovio), in-lab experiments, dyadic conversation, social network analysis, ecological momentary assessment (EMA), longitudinal studies.
Neuroimaging	fMRI data collection, processing, and analysis.
Computational	Natural language processing (NLP), LLM annotation & evaluation.

INDUSTRY EXPERIENCE

Flourish Science

Research Intern

July 2024 - Jan 2025

Remote

- Collaborated with design, product, and science teams to develop a new user activity for the Flourish app aimed at enhancing user well-being through meaningful social connections.
- Conducted user interviews, stakeholder analysis, and usability testing to iteratively inform product design.
- Refined prototypes using survey analysis; fine-tuned LLM prompts to optimize user experience and engagement.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Social Learning and Choice Lab (USC)

PhD Researcher (PI: Leor Hackel, Ph.D.)

2020 - Present

Los Angeles, CA

- Designed and conducted 20+ surveys and behavioral experiments ($N = 4000+$) on how emotion shapes moral behaviors and social connection; authored two peer-reviewed articles (*Psych Science*, *JESP*).
- Applied multilevel Bayesian models and longitudinal network analysis (RSiena, ERGM) to quantify the impact of social network dynamics on collective identification and well-being.
- Designed a dyadic conversation experiment ($N = 180$) to examine how emotion regulation shapes the trajectory of moral and political disagreements. Applied NLP tools and LLM-based annotation to conversation transcripts to evaluate intervention efficacy.
- Built Python pipelines to extract information from 100K+ support-seeking Reddit posts via fine-tuned RoBERTa classifiers; applied NLP (LIWC) to identify predictors of empathic engagement.

Social Cognitive & Affective Neuroscience Lab (Columbia)

2018 - 2020

Lab Manager and Research Coordinator (PI: Kevin Ochsner, Ph.D.)

New York, NY

- Coordinated a multi-site longitudinal social network study ($N = 800+$) tracking health behavior in college students across three waves over 18 months, standardizing survey administration.
- Created data cleaning and analysis pipelines in R and Python to merge site-level datasets and ensure consistent variable coding and reproducibility.
- Built fMRI experiment scripts in PsychoPy and ran 200+ fMRI sessions using a Siemens 3T scanner.
- Managed IRBs and supported successful renewal of three NIH grants (total $\approx$ \$3M).

PUBLICATIONS

- **Zhang, Y.** & Hackel, L. (2026). Generalization of rejection and acceptance in social networks. *Journal of Experimental Social Psychology*, 122, 104834.
- **Zhang, Y.** & Hackel, L. (2025). Reward association with mental states shapes empathy and prosocial behavior. *Psychological Science*, 36(9), 691-712.

WORKING PAPERS

- **Zhang, Y.**, Helion, C., & Hackel, L. Emotion regulation shapes response to moral disagreements in live conversations. *Manuscript in preparation*.
- **Zhang, Y.**, Helion, C., & Hackel, L. An emotion regulation framework of interpersonal moral disagreements. *Manuscript in preparation*.

TALKS & PRESENTATIONS

Invited Talks

- **Zhang, Y.** (2025). Emotion regulation shapes response to moral disagreements in live conversations. New York University (Van Bavel lab).
- **Zhang, Y.** (2023). An emotion regulation framework for interpersonal moral disagreements. University of Delaware (Mende-Siedlecki lab).

Conference Presentations

- **Zhang, Y.** (2026). Using social network approaches to understand social connection formation. Symposium chaired at SPSP, Chicago, IL.
- **Zhang, Y.** & Hackel, L. (2025). Reward association with mental states shapes empathy and prosocial behavior. Data blitz at SPSP, Denver, CO.
- **Zhang, Y.** & Hackel, L. (2024). Emotion regulation predicts response to moral disagreements in relational contexts. Poster at SPSP, San Diego, CA.
- **Zhang, Y.** & Hackel, L. (2023). Anticipated acceptance mediates the relationship between network density and social identification. Poster at SPSP, Atlanta, GA.
- **Zhang, Y.** & Hackel, L. (2022). Generalized response to social rejection and acceptance in social networks. Poster at SPSP, San Francisco, CA.
- **Zhang, Y.** & Hackel, L. (2021). Learning empathy via Pavlovian conditioning. Poster at Society for Affective Science, Virtual.
- **Zhang, Y.**, Stanoi, O., Ochsner, K., & Falk, E. (2020). Enhanced craving for alcohol in social contexts predicts centrality in undergraduate social networks. Poster at SPSP, New Orleans, LA.
- **Zhang, Y.**, Hill, A., & Freeman, J. (2018). Social identity shapes the perception of inter-group bias in racial and political contexts. Talk presented at the NYU Undergraduate Research Conference, New York, NY.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Programming	R, Python, SPSS, Bash, SQL, Javascript (Typescript, React), HTML/CSS
Software	Qualtrics, NVivo, Otree, Figma, Codex/Claude Code
Neuro Tools	FSL, PsychoPy, E-Prime, Mouse Tracker

FELLOWSHIPS & GRANTS

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|---|-------------|
| • USC Psychology Department Doctoral Research Grant Award (\$3,900) | 2024 - 2025 |
| • USC Psychology Department Travel Grant Award (\$1,250) | 2020 - 2025 |
| • Honorable mention, APS Student Grant | 2022 |
| • Dean's Undergraduate Research Fund (DURF), New York University | 2017 - 2018 |
| • Dean's List for Academic Year, New York University | 2014 - 2018 |

SERVICE & MEMBERSHIPS

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|---|----------------|
| • Member, Society for Personality and Social Psychology | 2018 - Present |
| • Member, Society for Affective Science | 2021 - Present |
| • Member, Association for Psychological Science | 2021 - Present |
| • Psi Chi, New York University Chapter | 2017 - 2018 |

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Guest Lecturer

- PSYC-355, Social Psychology Spring 2024, Spring 2025

Teaching Assistant

- PSYC-100, Introduction to Psychology Fall 2025, Spring 2023
- PSYC-274, Statistics Fall 2023, Fall 2022
- PSYC-165, Drugs, Behavior, and Society Spring 2025, 2024, 2022

SCIENCE WRITING & COMMUNICATION

- **Zhang, Y.** (July 2025). Reimagining empathy in the era of AI. *Medium*. <https://medium.com/@yzhang51/reimagining-empathy-in-the-era-of-ai-fde1117bec12>
- **Zhang, Y.** (May 2022). Do we still need empathy in a fractured world? (破碎世界, 我们还需要共情吗?) *Neu-reality (神经现实)*. <https://neu-reality.com/2022/05/against-empathy/>

REFERENCES

- **Leor Hackel, Ph.D.**
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- **Chelsea Helion, Ph.D.**
Assistant Professor of Psychology
Temple University
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- **Kevin Ochsner, Ph.D.**
Professor of Psychology
Columbia University
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- **Xuan Zhao, Ph.D.**
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Flourish Science
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